

Word family: **belief / beliefs / believe / believable / unbelievable**

Base word: belief

Plural: beliefs

Related forms: believe, believable, unbelievably, unbelievable

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / related verb and adjectives (相關動詞及形容詞)

Your sentence:

> “It seems to ask big questions about progress, **belief**, and civilisation...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **belief** means a **deeply held idea, conviction, or system of ideas that people accept as true or important**, especially in relation to society, religion, values, or how humans understand the world.

繁體中文： **信念；信仰；人們認為真實、正確或重要而接受的觀念或思想**

中文翻譯：

> “It seems to ask big questions about progress, **belief**, and civilisation...”

「它似乎會提出一些關於進步、**信念 / 信仰**和文明的大問題。」

Here:

belief = 人類對世界、價值、宗教或社會所持有並相信的觀念與信念

1. **belief = something you think is true (信念 / 看法) — 相信；信念；觀點**

This is the broad central meaning.

Meaning: An idea or opinion that you accept as true, even when it may not be objectively proven.

Practice 1

> “He has a strong **belief** that education can change lives.”

「他堅信教育可以改變人生。」

Practice 2

> “That **belief** influenced many of her decisions.”

「那個**信念**影響了她很多決定。」

belief = 一個人認為真實或正確，並接受為真的觀念

Common:

- * strong belief
- * deeply held belief
- * personal belief
- * belief that...

2. **belief** = religious faith or doctrine (宗教) — 信仰；宗教信念

Belief can refer specifically to religious faith or religious ideas.

Practice 3

> “People should be free to follow their religious **beliefs**.”

「人們應該有自由遵從自己的宗教**信仰**。」

Practice 4

> “The community has a wide range of religious **beliefs**.”

「這個社群有很多不同的宗教**信仰**。」

belief = 對宗教、神、靈性或宗教教義所持的信仰

This is highly relevant to your passage because a book about human history may discuss systems of shared belief.

3. **belief** = confidence/trust that something or someone is good, effective, or capable (信心)
— 信任；信心

Belief can mean confidence in a person, idea, system, or ability.

Practice 5

> “She never lost her **belief** in herself.”

「她從沒有失去對自己的****信心****。」

Practice 6

> “Public ****belief**** in the system has weakened.”

「公眾對這個制度的****信任****減弱了。」

****belief in someone/something = 相信某人 / 某事物的能力、價值或可靠性****

This is related to “accepting something as true,” but the mental concept is more specifically ****trust/confidence****.

4. ****belief = an organized system of ideas or values (思想體系) — 信念體系 ; 價值觀****

In social, cultural, historical, or philosophical contexts, ****belief**** can refer to a broader system of shared ideas.

Practice 7

> “The book examines how shared ****beliefs**** shaped early societies.”

「這本書探討共同的****信念體系****如何塑造早期社會。」

Practice 8

> “Cultural ****beliefs**** can influence behaviour.”

「文化****信念 / 觀念****可以影響行為。」

****beliefs = 一個群體共同接受的價值、觀念、宗教思想或世界觀****

This is the closest expansion of your passage meaning.

5. ****belief = opinion/judgment about what is likely or true (判斷) — 認為 ; 看法****

In expressions such as:

> “It is my belief that...”

****belief**** can mean a considered opinion or judgment.

Practice 9

> “It is my **belief** that the plan will succeed.”

「我**認為** / 相信**這個計劃會成功**。」

Practice 10

> “Contrary to popular **belief**, the process is not simple.”

「與普遍**看法**相反，這個過程並不簡單。」

belief = 對某件事情是否真實或成立所持的看法 / 判斷

For strict counting, I would merge this with Meaning 1.

Useful expression: **belief in** — 對.....的信心 / 信念

Practice 11

> “Her **belief in** the project remained strong.”

「她對這個項目的**信心**仍然很強。」

Practice 12

> “His **belief in** justice shaped his career.”

「他對正義的**信念**塑造了他的職業道路。」

This construction can mean either:

* confidence in something

* commitment to an idea/value

Context decides.

Useful expression: **belief that** — 相信.....

Practice 13

> “Their **belief that** change was possible kept them going.”

「他們**相信改變是可能的這種信念**使他們堅持下去。」

This belongs to the broad proposition/idea sense.

Useful expression: **contrary to popular belief** — 與普遍看法相反

Practice 14

> “Contrary to popular **belief**, the animal is not dangerous.”

「與普遍**看法**相反，這種動物並不危險。」

This is a very common fixed expression.

Related form: **believe**

Believe is the verb counterpart, but it has its own important patterns.

believe something = think it is true (相信某事是真的)

> “I believe his story.”

「我相信他的說法。」

believe in someone/something = have faith/confidence (相信 / 信任)

> “I believe in her.”

「我相信她的能力 / 我對她有信心。」

believe in an idea/religion = 信奉

> “They believe in freedom.”

「他們信奉自由。」

These distinctions line up closely with the noun branches above.

Related form: **believable**

Believable means seeming likely or realistic enough to be accepted as true.

Practice 15

> “The character felt believable.”

「這個角色令人覺得很**真實可信**。」

believable = 看起來合理、可信，讓人容易相信的

Related form: **unbelievable**

Unbelievable can mean either:

literally

too unlikely to be believed

> “The story sounded unbelievable.”

「這個故事聽起來**令人難以置信**。」

informally

extremely impressive, surprising, or bad

> “The view was unbelievable.”

「景色**令人難以置信地壯觀 / 非常驚人**。」

That informal intensifier use is a useful lexical extension.

Important distinction: **belief vs opinion**

opinion

= what you think or judge about something

belief

= something you accept as true or deeply hold

A belief is often deeper or more firmly held than an ordinary opinion.

> opinion about a film

> belief about human nature

Important distinction: **belief vs faith**

faith

often implies stronger trust without requiring proof and is especially common in religious contexts.

belief

is broader and can refer to:

* ordinary propositions

* values

* religion

* confidence

So:

> religious belief

> religious faith

Both work, but **faith** often sounds more personal or devotional.

Important distinction: **belief vs trust**

trust

emphasizes reliance on someone or something being honest, reliable, or capable.

belief

can simply mean accepting something as true.

> belief in an idea

> trust in a person

There is overlap in **belief in someone**.

Important distinction: **belief vs knowledge**

belief

= something accepted as true

knowledge

= information or understanding regarded as established through evidence, experience, or learning

A person can hold a belief without knowing it to be true.

Important distinction: **belief vs value**

belief

= what you think is true or right

value

= a principle or quality you consider important

For example:

> belief: "People can change."

> value: "Honesty matters."

They often interact but are not the same.

Countability note

Belief can be both countable and uncountable-ish depending on use.

Countable

> a belief

> several beliefs

when referring to specific ideas:

> “She has strong beliefs about education.”

Less countable / abstract

> belief in yourself

> belief in democracy

when referring to confidence or commitment more generally.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **belief**

* **beliefs**

* **believe**

* **believable**

* **unbelievable**

* **unbelievably**

The important semantic sweep is across:

* accepting propositions as true

* religious belief

* confidence/trust

* shared cultural or social belief systems

These should be separated when the underlying mental concept changes, but ordinary collocational variation should not create artificial extra meanings.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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belief — idea accepted as true	一個人認為真實、正確或成立的觀念 / 信念
belief — religious	對宗教、神、靈性或宗教教義所持的信仰
belief — confidence/trust	對某人、制度、能力或理念的信心與信任
beliefs — shared cultural/value system	某群體共同接受的價值、觀念、宗教思想或世界觀
belief — opinion/judgment	對某件事是否真實或成立所持的看法；通常可併入 general belief
believable	合理可信、容易讓人相信的

| **unbelievable**

| 難以置信的；口語中亦可表示極度驚人

|

For your original sentence

> “It seems to ask big questions about progress, **belief**, and civilisation...”

The exact meaning is:

belief = 人類共同接受並用來理解世界、組織社會或建立價值觀的信念與信仰

So:

> **questions about belief**

= **關於人類相信甚麼、為甚麼相信，以及這些信念如何塑造社會的問題**

For your database, I would count **4 genuinely useful core meanings** for **belief**:

1. **an idea or proposition accepted as true**
2. **religious faith or doctrine**
3. **confidence/trust in someone or something**
4. **a shared system of cultural/social values or ideas**

I would merge **“it is my belief that...”** into #1, keep **belief in** flexible between #3 and value-commitment contexts, and treat **believe / believable / unbelievable** as family extensions rather than inflate the noun count.